How to mix the colour and its shades

One name, several forms. In optics *violet* is the colour at the end of the spectrum and *purple* (magenta-like) is a mixture of red and blue light that the eye completes. In everyday speech they are not distinguished, and in paint swatches you will find a range of different mixtures under the name “violet”. **There is no single violet.** For our card, imagine a colour between red and blue in which both stay audible.

Ready-made tubes have their charm, but **mixing violet will teach you the most**. You will see how cool blue and warm red pull against each other, and when the colour lights up or turns grey. Start small, on paper, and write down what came from what.

What to prepare



Blue

Pushes the mix towards a cooler, blue-violet form.



A cooler red

Brings the mix closer to a warmer, red-violet. Look for a red that is closer to pink than to orange.



Purple, or magenta

A vivid pink-red with which you mix brighter violets.



White

Creates lighter lilac and lavender tones.



Yellow

In a tiny amount it mutes violet.



Ochre

Mutes more gently than yellow and suits heathery tones.



Brown

Helps with earthier plum and aubergine mixes.

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How can you recognise it without technical names?

Violet is made by mixing blue and red, but **not every pair gives a radiant result**. If the red has a distinctly orange tint, the mix turns out muted to brownish, because yellow secretly joins in. For a brighter violet it is easier to try **blue with magenta**, or with a red that is closer to pink than to orange.

On the tube look for the mark **PV** (Pigment Violet) and a number. It tells you which pigment the ready-made violet is made from, even if names differ between makers. A ready-made violet from a tube and a violet mixed from blue and red often behave differently, so put them side by side as a test.

What the additions do



Blue

Moves towards blue-violet, cooler, closer to indigo.





Magenta or red

Moves towards red-violet, warmer and more sensual. Add by the tip of the brush.





White

Lightens into lavender and lilac. Add little by little, or start with white.





Yellow

Mutes into a quieter, slightly stormy tone. Really just the tip of the brush, otherwise the colour turns somewhere else entirely.





Ochre

A gentler muting than yellow, heathery and dusty tones.





Brown

Adds earthiness, plum and aubergine depth. Too much brown makes it a dirty grey.



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Ten violets to try

A part can be a drop or an equally sized heap of paint. **Take the ratios as a starting point**, because the strength of individual pigments differs. The ratios are approximate, so try them on paper first.

Basic violet



1 part blue + 1 part cooler red. Fine-tune gradually according to the result.

Brighter violet



1 part blue + 1 part magenta, at first in roughly equal parts. Clean, rich, bold.

Blue-violet



2 parts blue + 1 part magenta. Calmer, cooler, closer to indigo.

Red-violet



2 parts magenta + 1 part blue. Warmer, more sensual, closer to pink.

Lavender



4 parts white + 1 part blue-violet. Delicate, dreamy, a little fragrant.

Lilac



3 parts white + 1 part violet, a drop of magenta if needed. Airy, springlike, soft.

Soft heather



3 parts white + 1 part red-violet + a tiny trace of ochre. Dreamy and a little autumnal.

Plum



3 parts red-violet + 1 part darker blue, added gradually; possibly a trace of brown. Full, deep, private.

Aubergine



4 parts dark violet + 1 part brown. Adjust the lightness as needed.

Dusty grey-violet



2 parts violet + 2 parts white + a really tiny trace of yellow (the tip of the brush). Quiet, elegant, a little stormy.

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